CLAN Ó COMÁIN

Newhall House · County Clare · Ireland

First Steps

in Tracing Your Irish Line

A starter guide from Newhall

Welcome

This is a short guide for anyone setting out to trace an Irish ancestor. It will not make you a professional genealogist in four pages, but it will get you past the first walls — the ones most diaspora researchers hit when they don't know which records exist or how to read them.

The Irish records are better than people expect. Civil registration, two excellent censuses, two great land surveys, parish registers stretching back to the eighteenth century in many cases — most of it free, much of it online, and far more searchable today than it was even ten years ago.

What follows is what we wish someone had handed us when we started. Begin at page two, and work forward in order — each step builds on the last.

1. Begin with what is already in the family

The temptation is to start with the records. Resist it for a day. The single most useful hour you can spend is on the phone with the oldest member of your family, asking three questions:

What was your grandmother's full maiden name? Spelling matters less than you think — Irish names were transcribed by English-speaking clerks who heard them once. Cummins, Commane, Comyn, Hurley and Coman can all sit on the same family tree.

Where in Ireland did the family come from? A county is good. A townland (a small named area of land, the smallest unit of Irish geography) is gold. A parish is between the two and almost as useful as a townland.

When did they leave? Year of emigration narrows everything. Pre-Famine (before 1845), Famine-era (1845–1852), or the long emigration (1850–1920) each point to different records.

Write what you learn down before the call ends. Old photographs, the back of mass cards, family bibles, and prayer books often carry names and dates the family has forgotten.

2. Civil registration (1864 onward)

From 1 January 1864, every birth, marriage and death in Ireland was recorded by the state. Catholic marriages from 1845 onward. The records are free, online, and searchable by name.

Go to irishgenealogy.ie — the official government site. Search by surname, county, and rough date range. The actual register page (handwritten by the local registrar) is scanned and viewable, free, with no account required.

This is usually where most diaspora researchers find their footing. A grandmother's birth certificate names her parents, the townland, and her father's occupation. Her parents' marriage certificate names their parents in turn. Two records and you are back to the early nineteenth century.

3. The 1901 and 1911 censuses

Ireland's two surviving full censuses are an extraordinary resource. They list every person living in every house on census night, with name, age, religion, occupation, county of birth, and whether they could read and write.

Both are free and fully searchable at census.nationalarchives.ie. Search by surname and townland; the original household form is scanned and you can see the household in the head of the family's own handwriting.

If your ancestor emigrated after 1911, they will be in one or both. If they emigrated earlier, their parents and siblings often will be — which gives you a Clare or Limerick or Galway townland anchor that all later searches can build outward from.

4. The two great land surveys

Griffith's Valuation (1847–1864) was a survey of every occupier of land or a building in Ireland, carried out as the basis for the new local rates. It names the head of every household, the townland, the landlord, and the size and value of the holding. Free at askaboutireland.ie. For most pre-1864 ancestors this is the closest thing you will find to a census.

The Tithe Applotment Books (1823–1837) are an earlier survey of land occupiers — less complete, less reliable, but for the early nineteenth century often the only record of a name in a place. Free at the National Archives of Ireland Genealogy site.

Together, these two surveys let you place a family in a specific townland decades before civil registration began.

5. Church records — back into the 1700s

Catholic parish registers in many parts of Ireland stretch back to the late eighteenth century. They record baptisms, marriages, and (less often) burials. They are usually in Latin, but the names and dates are perfectly readable.

The National Library of Ireland has digitised every Catholic parish register up to about 1880, free, at registers.nli.ie. Browse by parish, then by year. The handwriting takes some getting used to; persevere.

Church of Ireland and Presbyterian registers are scattered across various archives — RootsIreland.ie indexes many of them but charges for full views.

6. The major archives

National Library of Ireland (NLI) — nli.ie — Catholic parish registers, periodicals, manuscripts.

National Archives of Ireland (NAI) — nationalarchives.ie — censuses, Tithe Applotments, wills, court records.

PRONI (Public Record Office of Northern Ireland) — nidirect.gov.uk/proni — for ancestors from any of the historic Ulster counties.

FamilySearch — familysearch.org — free, run by the LDS Church, holds digitised copies of many Irish records and a global tree built collaboratively. A useful first stop.

Where this leads

With the records above, most diaspora researchers can put together a clear five-generation tree — back into the early nineteenth century — within a few weekends of work, at no cost. Beyond that the records get thinner and the work gets harder, but the foundation will be solid.

Clan Ó Comáin is an ancient Gaelic royal house and a recognised Irish Gaelic clan, authenticated by Clans of Ireland under the patronage of the President of Ireland. The Chief is Fergus Commane Kinfauns, seated at Newhall House in County Clare. The clan welcomes any who love Ireland and its Gaelic culture — whatever surname you carry, and whether or not your line runs into ours. The bond is what matters, not the bloodline.

Caithfidh an stair a bheith i réim — History must prevail

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